

Global Supply Chain Management Course Reflection Exercise:

LEARNING JOURNAL #1 (DUE DATE: November 24, 2025)

Learning within executive programs happens by reflecting and absorbing for yourselves the many stimulating ideas and industry practices you study while in the course. You need to absorb these ideas, reflect on them, state them in your own words, and then apply them in a situational context. Now that we have completed the first half of our course, I would like you to go through this reflection process and complete **LEARNING JOURNAL #1**. The assignment is quite flexible as you have the choice among three different tasks (**complete only ONE of them**, the one closest to your interests or your knowledge). Summarize your thoughts on it in a **three page write-up** (feel free to write more if that allows you to complete your thoughts, and you are free to add Appendices, if that helps making your argument complete). It is **due November 24, 2025 (by 5 pm)**. Send it to me as an email attachment (prefer PDF or Word file) at kouvelis@wustl.edu.

Task # 1: Global Supply Chains for Electric Cars in the Future.

Electric Vehicles (EVs), spearheaded by Tesla Innovations as early as 2006, proved to be a disruptive technology in the car industry, and especially so for the traditional internal combustion manufacturers (GM, Ford, BMW, Mercedes, Toyota, Nissan etc.). These companies will have to design global supply chains for delivering these new electric vehicles to their different markets, and at the same time have to deal with the emerging competitive intensity of the many Chinese EV manufacturers threatening their own markets. And all of these global supply chain design issues take place under geopolitical risks, uncertain tariffs on components and finished goods, shifting demand and technological uncertainty. Let us reflect on some of these issues:

Part 1: How do you think these supply chains will look (at a rather broad conceptual level, without getting into many details), and in what ways will they differ from the current supply chains the above manufacturers use? What is different in the nature of the products (electric cars vs. combustion engine ones) and how that will reflect in the design of the supply chains? Which parts of the supply chain may be the critical “bottlenecks” and cause shortages in the future?

Part 2: How the geopolitical tensions between US and China may affect the nature of these supply chains? How are recent government industrial policies (either from the US or China) may affect the structure of these supply chains? As a reminder, from the US government perspective there are imposed restrictions on chip flows from Chinese owned companies, and tariffs to offer incentives for batteries made mostly from US produced components for cars sold in the US. From the Chinese government side there are restrictions on rare earth minerals used in magnets and other critical components of EVs sold to European and US companies. What

challenges will companies face in an effort to build “resilient” supply chains in the EV industry under the current geopolitical tensions, instituted trade and non-trade barriers, and a highly competitive environment in an evolving technology industry?

Task #2: Tariff Shocks and Impact on Global Supply Chains: Discussion via an Industry Example

Since returning to office in 2025, President Trump has imposed duties and tariffs on a vast range of foreign-made goods (including steel and cars) imported into the United States. The tariffs were particularly high for goods coming from China (in April were threatened to be as high as 145%, later were delayed with a temporary level of around 30%). In the latest development (late October 2025), President Trump and the Chinese leader, Xi Jinping, agreed to a deal that reduces damaging trade war escalations between the world’s two large economies. The US announced it would reduce “fentanyl-linked” tariffs to only 10% from 20%, but other tariffs continue to apply to Chinese goods.

The tariffs have been applied to a long list of countries, with some of the significant ones to Brazil and India, and for certain products not covered under the USMCA treaty to Canada (faces tariffs up to 35%) and Mexico (tariffs up to 25%). Many of the tariffs imposed were industry-specific duties, with some of the noticeable ones the following:

Steel and aluminum (50%), copper (50%), autos and auto parts (25%), timber and lumber (10%), cabinets and vanities (25%), upholstered furniture (25%), heavy duty trucks (25%), and buses (10%).

Wearing your “global supply chain executive” hat, you would like to answer the following questions assuming you are running a global company in one of these industries currently importing materials, components and/ or finished goods in one of those industries (pick one you are familiar with and/ or you have enough references to rely on):

How are the tariffs at the above levels drive your supply chain restructuring, if any? Are you going to reshore manufacturing? Are you planning to find other suppliers in other countries? Are you planning to change the product portfolio you are offering to the US market? Are you going to aggressively price and pass on tariff costs to your consumers? In other words, what are the necessary actions to create a resilient supply chain in the current uncertain tariff environment for your company? Explain your logic of your supply chain strategy for the current environment. As part of your discussion, explain the way you plan to justify required investments in adjusting your sourcing network and/ or building new facilities, and what are the most important execution challenges in implementing your strategy for the next 4-5 years.

Task # 3: What are your predictions for the shortages and level of prices of goods for the coming holiday season?

Every day we read new stories about seriously bottlenecked supply chains, and shortages of essential items or services. But since April 2025 we heard a lot of stories about the geopolitical crises, trade wars, and the role of tariffs imposed on a variety of goods (toys, clothing, metals, electronics, leather, upholstery, wood, etc.) and for goods coming from all over the world (and especially from China). ***Play the role of the “supply chain expert and prognosticator” and write your “op-ed” piece on “Holiday Items in Short Supply” or “Buy Now instead of Wait for Unbelievable Holiday Discounts”*** (feel free to make your most interesting predictions) and try to provide the logic and arguments in support of your predictions.

Part 1: In the most recent news, we heard about the Trump administration quietly watering down some of the tariffs and especially the ones imposed on Chinese products (even though it is still at a 20-30% or so level for most products). Most of the supply chain experts will tell you that orders for traditional holiday items (like for example faux Christmas trees and toys) are placed many months in advance (six or more months in advance), and the uncertainty and frequent changes in tariff levels disturb the planning process. How do all these plays into your thinking? What are the (other) factors in the current environment, which will be driving your arguments (inflation, recession, shipping costs, trucking capacities, energy prices, weather, climate changes, wars, labor strikes, etc.)? Do you expect to get your popular basket of Christmas Holiday items (food, gifts, decorations, etc.) at the same, cheaper or more expensive prices as compared to last year? Why? Explain your logic.

Part 2: Are there any retailers you admire and expect to be able to better manage their inventories and assortments for the holiday season? What are the strategies they use to be more “resilient” in the current uncertain and challenging environment? Give us one or two such examples.